

SOP-01 Block Selection and Reservation (Quarry)

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Document control

Field	Detail
SOP number	SOP-01
Title	Block Selection and Reservation (Quarry)
Version	1.0
Owner	Founder & Managing Director, StoneCrest International
Applies to	Every export order, first container and repeat orders alike
Used by	StoneCrest block selection staff, quarry labour manager
Next SOP in sequence	SOP-02 Processing, Quality Control and Packing (Factory)
Review	Every 12 months, or after any quality complaint

Purpose and scope

No block goes into production for a buyer's order unless it has been checked, recorded and reserved under this SOP. It covers QC Stage 1 (pre-production check) of StoneCrest's 6-stage QC process.

Scope: every block selected for an export order, at every quarry StoneCrest sources from, for every grade and colour. The first container and every repeat order follow the same steps.

The reference for every check is the Approved Reference for that order: the agreed written specification, the photos and videos the buyer accepted, and the reference chip StoneCrest cuts and retains from the first selected block (Step 6).

The accepted photos and videos are saved in the order folder and kept on hand at the quarry and the factory, so every check is made against what the buyer actually agreed to.

Factory stock, a general "export quality" standard, or the quarry's own grading is never the reference.

Roles and responsibilities

StoneCrest selects and approves the block; the quarry supplies and prepares it. The final accept or reject decision always sits with StoneCrest, never with the quarry.

Role	Responsible for
Order Owner (StoneCrest)	Issues the Order Specification Sheet; confirms the Approved Reference; final sign-off before the block leaves the quarry
Block Selector (StoneCrest)	Inspects blocks at the quarry, runs the checks in this SOP, records results and photos, marks and reserves accepted blocks
Quarry Labour Manager	Presents candidate blocks, arranges handling equipment and water, opens test cuts and chips on instruction, keeps reserved blocks separate until dispatch
Quarry Owner / Supervisor	Confirms block availability and volume; signs the Block Reservation Record; releases the block only to StoneCrest's dispatch instruction

Inputs required before selection starts

Selection does not start until the Block Selector holds all five items below. If any one is missing, the visit is rescheduled.

1. **Order Specification Sheet:** order number, buyer, stone name and grade, finish, all sizes and thicknesses, quantity range per size, total m³ required.
2. **Approved Reference:** the agreed specification plus the photos and videos the buyer accepted.
3. **Block volume needed:** total m³ of finished stone plus cutting and processing loss (typically 35–50% extra for monument pieces; confirm with the factory for the size mix).
4. **Largest piece in the order:** the minimum clear block dimensions needed to cut it without joints or defects (for example, 200x100x15 cm needs a block with a clear face larger than 200x100 cm).
5. **Equipment at the quarry:** water supply, portable cutter or chisel for test cuts, handheld polisher and pads for test polish, measuring tape, camera or phone, marking paint and tags.

Premium grade acceptance criteria for blocks

A block is accepted only if it passes every criterion below when checked against the Approved Reference. One failure means the block is rejected for that order.

Criterion	Accept	Reject
Colour	Uniform deep black across all faces and inside the test cut	Grey, brown or green cast; patches lighter than the reference
Grain	Very fine, even grain matching the reference	Coarse, uneven or mixed grain
Tonal variation	Minimal, within the reference	Visible tonal bands or clouding
Veins and patterns	No visible white or grey veins, spots or patterns	Any visible white or grey vein, spot, streak or pattern
Cracks and soundness	No cracks, hairlines or open joints; clear ring when struck	Any crack, hairline or dull sound indicating a hidden fault
Inside colour	Test cut and test chip the same black as the surface	Colour inside differs from the surface
Test polish	Takes a deep, even mirror polish with no dull patches	Dull or patchy polish; visible pores or pitting
Clear size	Clear, defect-free area large enough for the largest piece in the order	Too small, or defects fall inside the usable area
Natural stone	No sign of dye, oil or colour treatment	Any treated surface; acetone on a white cloth leaves colour

Step-by-step block selection procedure

Every step is done in daylight, with the block wetted, and recorded on the Block Selection Checklist at the end of this SOP.

1. **Shortlist.** The Quarry Labour Manager presents candidate blocks. The Block Selector rejects on sight any block with visible cracks, veins or colour cast.
2. **Measure.** Record length, width and height of each shortlisted block and its gross m³. Check the clear area is large enough for the largest piece in the order.
3. **Surface check.** Wet all accessible faces with clean water. Compare colour, grain and tonal variation against the Approved Reference, using the accepted photos and videos, and the reference chip once one has been cut. Photograph every face.

4. **Soundness check.** Tap the block along its faces and edges with a hammer. A clear ring is accepted; a dull or broken sound means a hidden fault and the block is rejected or checked further.
5. **Test cut or test chip.** Open a small area on one edge (a chip or a short saw cut) to see the stone inside. The colour inside must match the surface. Photograph it.
6. **Test polish and reference chip.** Polish a small area, or a piece cut from the block, to mirror finish. Check it takes an even, deep polish. Keep this polished piece as the retained reference chip for the order and label it with the block number.
7. **Natural stone check.** Wipe a polished area with acetone on a clean white cloth. The cloth must stay clean.
8. **Decision.** Accept only if every criterion in the acceptance table passes. Record accept or reject, with the reason, on the checklist.
9. **Confirm volume.** Add up the accepted blocks. If the total is short of the block volume needed, repeat from Step 1. Do not accept a weaker block to make up volume.

Block marking, reservation and dispatch to factory

An accepted block is marked, reserved for one order only, and tracked by its block number until it is cut.

1. **Block number.** Give each accepted block a number in the format SC-[order no.]-B[01, 02...], for example SC-2026-014-B01.
2. **Marking.** Paint the block number on two opposite faces, plus StoneCrest's mark. Photograph the block with the number visible.
3. **Reservation.** Enter each block on the Block Reservation Record (block number, dimensions, m³, photos, date). The Quarry Owner or Supervisor signs it. From this point the block is not sold, swapped or moved without StoneCrest's written instruction.
4. **Separate storage.** The Quarry Labour Manager keeps reserved blocks apart from general stock until dispatch.
5. **Dispatch.** Blocks leave the quarry only on StoneCrest's dispatch instruction. The Block Selector or Order Owner checks the block numbers on the truck against the Reservation Record and photographs the loaded truck.
6. **Handover to factory.** The factory signs for each block number on arrival. The block numbers and the retained reference chip travel with the order into SOP-02.

Rejection and non-conformance handling

A rejected block is never used for the order, whatever the time or volume pressure.

- **At selection:** record the reason for rejection and a photo on the checklist. The block stays with the quarry and is not marked.
- **Found after reservation** (for example, a crack that appears during handling): stop, photograph it, cancel the reservation for that block number, and select a replacement block under this SOP. Inform the Order Owner the same day.
- **Found at the factory** (a defect inside the block that shows only when cut): the factory stops cutting that block and follows SOP-02. Replacement volume is selected under this SOP.
- **Volume shortfall:** if accepted blocks can't cover the order, the Order Owner informs the buyer of any change to the production date. The standard is not lowered to keep the date.

Records, photo evidence and sign-off

Every accepted block has a complete record before it leaves the quarry. The records are kept for at least 3 years and can be shown to the buyer or their inspector.

Record	Content	Signed by
Block Selection Checklist	Results of every check, accept or reject with reason	Block Selector
Block Reservation Record	Block numbers, dimensions, m ³ , date reserved	Block Selector, Quarry Owner or Supervisor
Photo set per block	All faces wet, test cut or chip, test polish, block number painted	Block Selector
Retained reference chip	Polished piece from the block, labelled with block number	Kept by StoneCrest until the order is delivered
Dispatch record	Block numbers loaded, truck photo, date	Block Selector or Order Owner

Photos are saved to the order folder the same day, named by block number, for example SC-2026-014-B01_face1.jpg.

Block Selection Checklist (form)

One checklist per block, filled in at the quarry and signed before the block is reserved.

Field	Entry
Order number	
Block number	
Quarry	
Date	
Dimensions (L x W x H, cm)	
Gross volume (m ³)	

Check	Pass	Fail	Notes / photo reference
Colour matches Approved Reference			
Grain fine and even			
Tonal variation minimal			
No visible veins, spots or patterns			
No cracks; clear ring when struck			
Inside colour matches surface (test cut or chip)			
Takes even mirror polish (test polish)			
Acetone test: cloth stays clean			
Clear area fits the largest piece in the order			

Check	Pass	Fail	Notes / photo reference
Reference chip cut and labelled			

Decision: Accepted / Rejected. Reason if rejected: _____

Block Selector (StoneCrest): name, signature, date _____

Quarry Owner or Supervisor: name, signature, date _____